It was after much persuasion by a common friend and a popular figure that I agreed to meet Siby Mathews. The ISRO spy case was long rotting in history's dustbin after the Supreme Court had ruled in my favour and the National Human Rights Commission asked the Kerala Government to pay me compensation. I was still fighting to get punishment for the officers of the IB and the Kerala Police named in the CBI report. And Siby was worried of getting punishment not just from the government, but from God, as I was soon to realise.

Siby was with his wife at the friend's place by the time I reached there. I controlled my rage at the very sight of the officer, but kept my composure. After Siby tried to explain that he was dragged into the whole affair and had no intention to harm me, it was left to his wife to do the crucial part of the talking. She explained that her husband—and the family as a whole— is facing a 'divine punishment'.

She knew my wife Meena's daily visits to temples, and it appeared that the couple were worried that she was doing special prayers to harm Siby Mathews.

The rendezvous, that soon ended, did not get any more pleasant.

By 1998, when I came to know of Ratan Sehgal's forced exit as IB Joint Director because of his secret meetings with CIA agents, the Supreme Court had ruled in my favour, dismissing the Kerala Government's executive order for further investigation into the ISRO spy case. I could not resist the temptation to visit Arun Bhagat, the new IB director, to know if Sehgal's CIA connections had anything to do with the ISRO spy case.

As an R&AW officer then, Bhagat had interrogated me. He did not have a clear answer to my question. He said when he was involved in the ISRO investigation, he was not aware of Sehgal's dalliance with CIA officials, and hence could not comment on any correlation. My next question was point blank, 'Why did you let Sehgal take voluntary retirement, and not prosecute him?'

He said something to the effect that international relations are not drawn in black and white, and some allowances have to be made under some